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Does Venus Militaris,
Also, Preside Over the
Evil-Doing of Camps...

[The Seven Books of Arnobius Against the Heathen — Arnobius](#)

Does Venus Militaris, also, preside over the evil-doing [\[4112\]](#) of camps, and the debaucheries of young men? Is there one Perfica, [\[4113\]](#) also, of the crowd of deities, who causes those base and filthy delights to reach their end with uninterrupted pleasure? Is there also Pertunda, who presides over the marriage [\[4114\]](#) couch? Is there also Tutunus, on whose huge members [\[4115\]](#) and horrent fascinum you think it auspicious, and desire, that your matrons should be borne? But if facts themselves have very little effect in suggesting to you a right understanding of the truth, are you not able, even from the very names, to understand that these are the inventions of a most meaningless superstition, and the false gods of fancy? [\[4116\]](#) Puta, you say, presides over the pruning of trees, Peta over prayers; Nemestrinus [\[4117\]](#) is the god of groves; Patellana is a deity, and Patella, of whom the one has been set over things brought to light, the other over those yet to be disclosed. Nodutis is spoken of as a god, because he [\[4118\]](#) brings that which has been sown to the knots: and she who presides over the treading out of grain, Noduterensis; [\[4119\]](#) the goddess Upibilia [\[4120\]](#) delivers from straying from the right paths; parents bereaved of their children are under the care of Orbona, -- those very near to death, under that of Nænia. Again, [\[4121\]](#) Ossilago herself is mentioned as she who gives firmness and solidity to the bones of young children. Mellonia is a

goddess, strong and powerful in regard to bees, caring for and guarding the sweetness of their honey.

Footnotes:

[4112] So the ms. reading *flagitiis*, followed by all edd. except LB. and Orelli, who read *plagiis*--"kidnapping."

[4113] Of this goddess, also, no other author makes mention but the germ may be perhaps found in Lucretius (ii. 1116-7), where nature is termed *perfica*, i.e., "perfecting," or making all things complete. [The learned translator forgets Tertullian, who introduces us to this name in the work Arnobius imitates throughout. See vol. iii. [p. 140.]

[4114] i.e., in *cubiculis præsto est virginalem scrobem effodientibus maritis*.

[4115] The first five edd. read *Mutunus*. Cf. ch. 11. [I think it a mistake to make *Mutubus* = *Priapus*. Their horrible deformities are diverse, as I have noted in European collections of antiquities. The specialty of *Mutunus* is noted by our author, and is unspeakably abominable. All this illustrates, therefore, the Christian scruples about marriage-feasts, of which see vol. v. note 1, p. 435.]

[4116] Lit., the "fancies" or "imagination" of false gods. Meursius proposed to transpose the whole of this sentence to the end of the chapter, which would give a more strictly logical arrangement; but it must be remembered that Arnobius allows himself much liberty in this respect.

[4117] Of these three deities no other mention is made.

[4118] The ms., LB., Hild., and Oehler read *qui*--"who brings;" the other edd., as above, *quia*.

[4119] So the ms. (cf. ch. 11), first five edd., Oberth., Hild., and Oehler; the other edd. read *Nodutim Ter*.

[4120] So the ms., both Roman edd., and Oehler; the other edd. reading *Vibilia*, except Hild., *Viabilia*.

[4121] The ms. reads nam--"for," followed by all edd. except Orelli, who reads jam as above, and Oehler, who reads etiam--"also."



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